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Mahatma Gandhi Institute of  
Education for Peace and  
Sustainable Development

## **Skill 5: Impartiality and Common Humanity**

### **Module Objectives**

**By the end of this skill, you will be able to:**

- Define Bias
- Identify what all human beings have in common
- Explain impartiality and common humanity
- Identify explicit and implicit bias and techniques to weaken them
- Practice tools to cultivate impartiality

### **What do you understand by bias?**

It's natural for us to have biases, even if we're not always aware of them. Biases help us quickly understand the world by categorizing people and things based on our experiences, biology, and culture. This ability to quickly label and categorize has been helpful for survival. For example, if we see a large, growling animal, we instantly recognize it as dangerous and avoid it, which could save our lives.

However, while categorizing can be useful, it becomes a problem when we start to see these categories as fixed and unchanging. This can lead us to put people into groups—like "those who are like me" (in-group) and "those who are not like me" (out-group).

In-group bias is a thinking trap that can lead to stereotypes and the belief that certain groups have a fixed nature (essentialism). For example, we might think that all people of a certain race or religion are the same. But it's important to remember that these categories are just labels and don't define a person's true nature.

If we're not careful, these categories can make us view out-groups as less human or even evil, which can justify negative behaviors like discrimination, unfair treatment, or violence. This thinking trap prevents us from seeing the common humanity we all share.

## **Stereotype**

A **stereotype** is a fixed idea or image that people often have about a certain type of person or thing. For example, if the words "old lady," "bully," "cowboy," or "terrorist" make you instantly think of a certain type of person, then these ideas have become stereotypes for you.

Stereotypes can be based on things like nationality, religion, gender, race, or age. They can be both positive and negative.

For instance, a positive stereotype might be, "People from Country Y are good students" or "Families in Country Z are great hosts." But negative stereotypes can lead to false beliefs and even result in prejudice or discrimination.

## **Prejudice**

**Prejudice** is a negative attitude or feeling towards someone or a group of people, usually formed without knowing them personally. When we have prejudiced attitudes, we tend to judge everyone in that group the same way, instead of seeing each person as unique.

For example, if someone has a prejudice against a particular nationality, they might assume that everyone from that country is rude or unfriendly, even though they've never met anyone from there.

Prejudice stops us from learning about people who are different from us. Because of this, we can miss out on meaningful relationships and conversations that could have been really rewarding.

## **Understanding Impartiality and Common Humanity**

**Common humanity** means focusing on what all people have in common, like our shared desire for happiness and to avoid suffering.

**Impartiality** is about reducing the strong biases that make us favor one group over another. It doesn't mean we stop caring about our loved ones or treat everyone exactly the same. Instead, it means learning to value and appreciate people who are outside our usual circles—like strangers or those in different groups—by recognizing our shared humanity.

Think of the sun: it shines its light on everyone without favoring one person or group, yet it naturally shines brighter on those who are closer. Similarly, we often feel more compassion and kindness toward those who are close to us, but this doesn't have to create a bias that makes us think they deserve more happiness than others.

Even though it's natural to feel more connected to people we know well, this doesn't mean we can't also care about others. Impartiality is about broadening our compassion to include everyone, not just those closest to us.

It's normal for impartiality to be challenging because we naturally form groups and biases. But with practice, we can learn to extend our feelings of common humanity to more people, treating them with the same kindness and respect we give to those we know well.

Let's now try one activity

### **Who are you Activity**

Follow these instructions to do this activity:

1. Get a piece of paper and a pen.
2. Write down "Who Are You" in the middle.
3. Select Start Timer.
4. Create a mind map around this question with different words that come to mind for 90 seconds.
5. Once the timer is up, take a few minutes to think about the question and your responses.
6. When you're ready, restart the timer by selecting Start Timer.
7. Do the activity again without using any labels or repeating the words used before.

### **Reflective questions**

1. What insights emerged for you during this activity?
2. What were the differences in your answers between the two rounds?
3. What does this activity reveal about our identities?
4. How many identities do you think we have?
5. How many of our identities are seen by someone when they first meet us?
6. What might this activity show us about label